



Security Council

Seventy-eighth year

Provisional

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th meeting

Thursday, 15 June 2023, 10 a.m.

New York

President: Mrs. Alhefeiti (United Arab Emirates)

Members:

Albania	Mr. Spasse
Brazil	Mr. De Almeida Filho
China	Mr. Sun Zhiqiang
Ecuador	Mr. Montalvo Sosa
France	Mr. Olmedo
Gabon	Ms. Betoé Ndojombouet
Ghana	Ms. Oppong-Ntiri
Japan	Mr. Ishikane
Malta	Mr. Camilleri
Mozambique	Mr. Fernandes
Russian Federation	Ms. Evstigneeva
Switzerland	Mr. Hauri
United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland . .	Mr. Eckersley
United States of America	Mr. Kelley

Agenda

Reports of the Secretary-General on the Sudan and South Sudan

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The meeting was called to order at 10 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

Reports of the Secretary-General on the Sudan and South Sudan

The President (*spoke in Arabic*): In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representative of the Sudan to participate in this meeting.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

At this meeting, the Council will hear a briefing by Ambassador Carolyn Oppong-Ntiri, Deputy Permanent Representative of Ghana to the United Nations, on behalf of the Chair of the Security Council Committee established pursuant to resolution 1591 (2005), concerning the Sudan.

I now give the floor to Ambassador Oppong-Ntiri.

Ms. Oppong-Ntiri (Ghana): In accordance with paragraph 3 (a) (iv) of resolution 1591 (2005), I have the honour to brief the Security Council on the work of the Sudan Sanctions Committee, covering the period from 21 March 2023 to today.

During the reporting period, the Committee met once in informal consultations and received the Sudan Panel's first quarterly update.

On 12 May, the Committee heard a briefing by the Sudan Panel of Experts on its work programme for the period 2023 to 2024 and on the current situation in Darfur. The Coordinator provided the Committee with an overview of the Panel's intended areas of investigation and monitoring, in accordance with the mandate as extended by resolution 2676 (2023). On 18 May, the Committee issued a press release (SC/15288) regarding that briefing.

On 6 June, the Sudan Panel of Experts submitted its first quarterly update to the Committee. The Panel updated us about regional dynamics and conflict dynamics in Darfur, including about escalating violence in parts of Darfur.

The President (*spoke in Arabic*): I thank Ambassador Oppong-Ntiri for her briefing.

I now give the floor to the representative of the Sudan.

Mr. Mohamed (Sudan) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to congratulate you, Madam President, on your country's assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for the current month and to thank the Deputy Chair of the Sanctions Committee established pursuant to resolution 1591 (2005) for her quarterly briefing.

Resolution 1591 (2015) is limited to the Darfur region. However, the regional impact of events has led to the influx of displaced persons. Accordingly, we would like to note the following.

The Sudan's relations with its neighbours have not been affected by the humanitarian situation, although military clashes necessarily have negative effects. The Sudan has not received notification that displaced persons and refugees who have reached the borders of certain countries have caused a national security breach.

There are attempts to smuggle high-quality weapons, such as anti-aircraft missiles, to support the insurgency, but the Sudanese security forces are keeping a close eye on that.

Most countries have positively committed themselves to neutrality, especially since Chad closed its borders to prevent rebel forces from infiltrating into its territories, arrested those who succeeded in penetrating and notified the Sudan of that. There are reports of some Chadian opposition factions being involved with the rebel forces. We thank the Chadian Government for its cooperation in that area.

With regard to the situation of Sudanese refugees in Chad, specifically in the camps at Wadi Sila and Wadi Fira, the Chadian Government has underscored its solidarity with the Sudan, where 113,000 Sudanese refugees fled their homes after violations committed by the Rapid Support Forces and are being welcomed by local communities. The returnees include 25,000 people, most of whom are women and children.

As for the Sudan's north-west border, supplies are being provided in support of the rebel forces.

The border with the Central African Republic is open and calm, but there are efforts by the rebels to exploit that, as I will explain later.

Our borders with the Arab Republic of Egypt are also open and calm. Egypt welcomed thousands of our citizens after the recent events, and we thank the Egyptian leadership and for that.

As for the Ethiopian border, security is stable and there is no indication that that Ethiopia's national security has been affected by the events. Ethiopia opened its doors to receive refugees, and a small number of them have arrived there.

Some delegations in the Council pointed out at a previous meeting that relations between the Sudan and South Sudan could deteriorate due to the return of southern refugees. But that did not happen. The information we have received about the situation of South Sudanese refugees in the Jabalain border area is as follows.

More than 365,000 refugees were hosted, including about 122,000 who arrived in the region from Khartoum after the recent clashes and settled in local camps, according to the latest official statistics released on 10 May.

With regard to the humanitarian situation in the Darfur region, large quantities of humanitarian and health assistance have been distributed by the World Food Programme — in areas of Central Darfur, North and West Jebel Marra, Mukjar, Um Dukhan, Wadi Saleh and Zalingei; in areas of South Darfur in Nyala, Kas, Gereida and Balil; and in areas South Kordofan in Abu Jubaiha, Abukarshola, Delami, Dillang, Liri, Qadir, Kadugli, Rashad and Talodi. In Central Darfur, 101,617 have beneficiaries received humanitarian assistance, as well as 33,120 in East Darfur, 134,946 in North Darfur and 89,769 in South Darfur.

I turn now to the current humanitarian situation in Central, West and East Darfur, namely, the El Geneina-Zalingei-Nyala triangle.

Attacks by the militia rebelling against the armed forces and attacks by other militias affiliated with it against the population of the states of Darfur, particularly in the city of El Geneina, capital of West Darfur state, have created a terrible humanitarian situation, whereby civilians are targeted based on their identity and the critical infrastructure for providing basic services has been destroyed. That situation requires an urgent humanitarian response.

In that regard, we express our thanks and appreciation to all sisterly and friendly countries, international, regional, governmental and non-governmental organizations, as well as local and foreign civil society organizations, that responded to the humanitarian appeal launched by the Government of the Sudan and contributed to the provision of urgently needed assistance, which had

a significant impact on alleviating the humanitarian crisis and responding to the urgent situation. However, more is needed, particularly in the West Darfur state, which experienced major events.

I regret to inform the Council that the militias backed by the Rapid Support Forces yesterday arrested the Governor of West Darfur state, Mr. Khamis Abdullah Abkar, and subsequently brutally killed him. It is worth mentioning that Mr. Abkar represented one of the signatories to the Juba Peace Agreement. Like other signatories, he maintained a neutral position. May God have mercy on his soul.

The Sudanese Government underscores its commitment to facilitate the entry and movement of humanitarian workers, grant them the necessary entry visas and permits and ensure their safety to perform their humanitarian tasks as required. The Government will also continue to facilitate the procedures for the entry of aid from ports and airports, including the possibility of transporting and distributing it in accordance with a map of needs for all states affected by the crisis. We stress the need to exert maximum pressure on the rebel forces and the militias allied with them in order to stop their crimes and aggression, oblige them to facilitate humanitarian pathways, avoid exposing humanitarian workers to danger and withdraw their military presence from residential areas.

I turn next to the status of resolution 1591 (2005). We have told the Council on previous occasions that, because of the arms embargo imposed on the armed forces, resolution 1591 (2015) has contributed to weakening the prestige and presence of the State in Darfur and its ability to maintain security and protect civilians. That has tipped the balance in favour of armed groups and restricted the Government's efforts to maintain security. We believe that the lack of financial support and the failure to fulfil pledges by the international community in support of the disarmament, demobilization and reintegration of combatants from armed movements and the parties to the Juba Peace Agreement have also affected the implementation of the Agreement in a satisfactory manner. The presence of heavily armed rebel forces in the Darfur region is also a cause for concern.

It has been proven that foreign elements participated with militia fighters, some of whom openly took videos during their participation in the fighting, including of advanced smart weapons, which were then leaked to the Taiba camp of the militia forces and were found in underground fortified containers.

Violence, including widespread looting, the burning of homes and public and Government facilities alike, and the destruction of infrastructure, markets, schools, hospitals and drug stores are all crimes committed by the militias. There has also been targeting of military sites of the armed forces in Darfur, as well as airports and bridges in the case of Zalingei and El Geneina.

The pattern of militia crimes is repeated at the same pace and targets the destruction of the Sudanese State in collusion with parties who will be revealed at a later time. This element must be referred to in United Nations reports, because neutrality in the face of crimes amounting to war crimes and crimes against humanity is tantamount to encouraging the continuation of such crimes.

The refugees who went to Chad did so because of the militia's planned attacks to depopulate the territory and seize it, in the same manner that the militia did when it violated the sanctity of property and the right to life and placed the population in harsh living conditions. That is a matter that falls under international law.

The security vacuum that exacerbated the tribal clashes in Darfur and the other ensuing clashes would not have taken place had the long-standing resolution 1591 (2015) been rescinded, which weakened the Sudanese armed forces and undermined their role in protecting the citizens of Darfur. The militia even targeted the joint force between Chad and the Sudan.

Certain tribes were also targeted by the militia, which even prevented the evacuation of the wounded after hospitals had been destroyed. The militia and its allies were storming homes door to door with pre-prepared lists of targets. The crimes committed in Khartoum and Darfur and the targeting and killing of citizens during the ongoing war are now being repeated in the present scenario of killing on the basis of ethnic identity.

With regard to civil peace, we ask the United Nations to support efforts to that end. In parallel with the official efforts of the Government of the Sudan, there are other efforts under way by civil society organizations to calm the situation and address the effects of the war. In that context, civilian members of South Darfur state signed a social compact and a community agreement that included 80 tribes, as part of the efforts of the community initiative in the state to stop the war and restore civilian life.

To address the situation in El Geneina and West Darfur state, an emergency meeting was held with the Governor of the Darfur region and Governors from other

Darfur states. They all visited El Geneina, the capital of West Darfur State, led by the Governor of the region and accompanied by volunteers from medical teams, civil administrations, national organizations and others to check the security and humanitarian situation on the ground and work with state authorities to defuse the crisis, establish security and achieve peace after the bloody events that the state experienced over the past several days. Medicines and shelter supplies located in Port Sudan were sent and distributed via the airports at El Fasher and Nyala to those affected. That also included securing all internal and national roads to and from Darfur, which requires that priority be given to peacebuilding operations and providing the necessary support to consolidate them during the upcoming qualitative phase of the United Nations Integrated Transition Assistance Mission in the Sudan.

The militia forces are currently besieging the Um Dafoug border region between the Central African Republic and the Sudan. That is happening before the autumn season with the aim to place military vehicles in that region. That is a matter of concern because it will be followed by attacks that target killing people based on their identity. We warn that, if not condemned, such events will threaten security from Khartoum to the Sahel. The international community shall bear the responsibility for being silent about such events.

We notice that there are attempts to connect the south of Libya with the Darfur region with the aim of moving military vehicles in support of the militia forces.

Turning to the Government's unit to combat violence against women and children, the harassment of women by militia elements has led to a high level of conflict-related sexual violence in Khartoum. No updates have been received on the Darfur region. The militias are carrying out kidnappings and demanding large ransoms. The militias are targeting diplomats and Sudanese Ambassadors who gave statements against them by attacking their homes and looting their properties. The Government's unit for combating violence against women and children notes an increase in kidnapping and mass gender-based violence in Khartoum, much of it targeting young girls. Most of those crimes have been attributed to forces wearing the uniform of the Rapid Support Forces, according to witness testimony. The unit is documenting those crimes with the aim of ending impunity.

The meeting rose at 10.20 a.m.